WORLD WAR I



German battleship
Prinzregent Luitpold was a German Kaiser-class battleship, launched in 1912 as part of Germany's rapid naval expansion in the run-up to World War I. She fought at Jutland in 1916—the only occasion opposing battleships dueled in the war—and was scuttled with the rest of the High Seas Fleet at Scapa Flow in 1919.

PUBLIC INTEREST IN NAVAL AFFAIRS has never been greater than in the lead-up to World War I. German naval expansion, perceived as a threat to British security, triggered an expensive arms race in which the two countries competed to build bigger and better battleships. This growing hostility led to an agreement between Britain and France to split responsibility for naval defense in case of war, Britain taking on the English Channel and North Sea while France looked after the Mediterranean. Given this build-up, World War I undoubtedly proved a disappointment to naval enthusiasts. Although major engagements between surface warships did occur, a decisive Trafalgar-style battle simply did not come off. Instead the British and German battle fleets sparred and shadow-boxed indecisively while struggling to come to terms with the deadly threat posed by unglamorous submarines and mines.

DISTANT BLOCKADE

Britain entered World War I with clear naval superiority over Germany. The Royal Navy had 52 dreadnoughts, pre-dreadnoughts, and battlecruisers, as against 34 comparable German warships. Inevitably the German High Seas Fleet was unwilling to steam out and engage in a full-scale battle in the face of such unfavorable odds. Yet the Royal Navy could not bottle up the German navy with a close blockade of enemy ports as it had in the Napoleonic Wars, because of the extreme vulnerability of its large surface warships to submarines, mines, and torpedo boats. British naval dominance of the entrances to the English Channel and the North Sea was enough to close Germany off from world trade, but this blockade was so distant that squadrons of German warships were able to sortie from harbor and shell the east coast of England.

German strategy was to weaken the Royal Navy by piecemeal sinkings until numbers were even enough for a showdown. The caution of Admiral Sir John Jellicoe, commander of the Grand Fleet, ensured that this never happened. His determination to keep the British fleet intact was matched by Kaiser Wilhelm's concern to preserve his prized warships. The German High Seas Fleet was more aggressively led for a time after Admiral Reinhard Scheer took command in January 1916, and the British succeeded in luring Scheer into a fleet battle at Jutland the following May. The battle revealed defects in the Royal Navy—for instance, much of its gunnery was inferior to that of the Germans—and was claimed as a German victory in terms of ships lost and damaged. Yet it was fought as a defensive battle by a German fleet running for home and German surface warships hardly left port again for the rest of the war.

U-BOAT MENACE

The ease with which capital ships could be sunk by mines and submarines had been predicted before the war, yet navies were slow to develop countermeasures. They had continued to create ever bigger, faster, and more heavily gunned battleships, which over

WEAPONS AND TECHNOLOGY

DREADNOUGHTS AND SUPER-DREADNOUGHTS

The launch of the British battleship *Dreadnought* in December 1906 ignited an international naval arms race. With ten 12-in guns and steam turbine engines giving a maximum speed of 21 knots, *Dreadnought* outclassed every other warship afloat. Its name became the general term for the new generation of battleships that started to appear around the world, including the South Carolina class in the United States, Germany's Nassau class, and France's Courbet class. The Royal Navy was determined to stay ahead of the competition and introduced even more powerful battleships dubbed "super-dreadnoughts." The first of these, *Orion*, launched in 1910, had 13.5-in guns, but the much admired Queen Elizabeth class, built between 1912 and 1915, mounted astonishing 15-in guns. Combined with heavy armor and oil-fired engines generating a maximum speed of 24 knots, this made for a truly formidable fighting machine.



Top of her class
Dreadnought may have represented the new kind of battleship that every navy hoped to acquire, but she had her faults. The arrangement of the main guns with three turrets in line and two at the sides was not a success, and with the mainmast just behind the front funnel, life was not easy for men in the spotting top.

Super-dreadnought
Conqueror was an Orion-class battleship launched in 1911, the next generation after *Dreadnought*.

